

# **Dissertation Title:** Migration, Cultural Hybridity, and Traditional Authority: The Cultural Formation of the Ubulubu Migrant Community in Nigeria

## **Description**

This study will investigate the cultural formation of the Ubulubu people, a historically migrant community in Aniocha North Local Government Area of Delta State, Nigeria, examining how migration, linguistic continuity, performative traditions, and indigenous authority systems constitute their cultural identity. According to oral traditions, the Ubulubu trace their origins to Owo, a Yoruba town in Ondo State, but later settled among predominantly Igbo populations. Over generations, this migration resulted in a unique cultural configuration that simultaneously preserves Yoruba linguistic elements while incorporating features from surrounding cultures.

The Ubulubu language, while closely related to Yoruba, reflects sustained intercultural contact and adaptation, representing not cultural erosion but dynamic resilience (Qani, 2025). The community's ritual life centers on the Igue festival, a ceremonial tradition originally associated with the Benin Kingdom, where it marks the spiritual renewal of the Oba and the protection of the kingdom's people (Osatohanmwon, 2024 and Wikipedia, 2025). In the Ubulubu context, the festival has been localized through distinctive practices such as the Okpodudu masquerade, featuring a two-faced wooden mask (*Odo*) and *Uko* raffia costume. Similar West African masquerade forms often perform social and mystical functions, mediating ancestral presence and reinforcing community cohesion as can be seen in Yoruba Egungun and Igbo Ijele traditions.

Another performative element is the Egwu Efifie dance, exclusive to Ubulubu ceremonial contexts, which functions as a ritualized expression of identity and communal history. Dance and ritual in African contexts often represent historical memory embodied in collective practice. Traditionally, Ubulubu authority is organized through a rotational kingship system (Obi Mbuyali) based on senior chieftaincy titles rather than age or direct heredity, diverging from both Yoruba and Igbo models of leadership. This structure reflects negotiated authority emerging from historical contingencies, demonstrating how political systems evolve in migrant communities. Taken together, these cultural forms reveal how the Ubulubu community engages in cultural hybridity through processes of preservation, adaptation, and negotiation in their socio-historical context.

## **Research Questions**

1. In what ways does the Ubulubu language exhibit Yoruba roots while incorporating influences from intercultural contact?
2. How has the Igue festival been transmitted and transformed within the Ubulubu cultural domain?
3. What symbolic meanings do the Okpodudu masquerade, the two-faced *Odo* mask, and *Uko* costume convey in Ubulubu cosmology?
4. How does the Egwu Efifie dance function as a site of ritual memory and community identity?
5. What are the historical origins and sociopolitical implications of the Obi Mbuyali rotational kingship system?

## **Objectives**

1. To reconstruct the migration history of the Ubulubu people through oral traditions.
2. To analyze linguistic resilience and transformation as a cultural continuity mechanism.
3. To document and interpret performative and ritual traditions in historical context.
4. To examine indigenous authority as negotiated socio-historical practice.
5. To situate Ubulubu cultural hybridity within broader debates in African historical and cultural studies.

## **Relevance of the Topic and Research Gap**

Although existing research addresses major ethnic identities, migrant and hybrid cultural formations remain underexplored within Nigerian and West African historiography. Specifically, less is known about how transplanted ceremonial forms like the Igue festival maintain meaning outside their original context, or how language preservation operates in migrant communities. The Ubulubu case offers a critical lens for understanding cultural transmission, adaptation, and authority in contexts of prolonged intercultural contact.

## **Embedding in Current Research**

The project engages with interdisciplinary scholarship in cultural hybridity, migration, ritual performance, and indigenous authority. It builds on emerging analyses of hybridity in African cultural forms and contributes to studies of festival traditions and political systems in West Africa.

## **Theoretical Framework**

This dissertation is informed by cultural hybridity theory, viewing identity as historically constructed through exchange and negotiation; performance theory, focusing on ritual enactment as embodied history; and indigenous political theory, examining non-hereditary systems of authority.

## **Methodology**

1. Oral history collection and genealogical interviews,
2. Ethnographic fieldwork during festival and ceremonial cycles,
3. Participant observation of masquerade and dance practices,
4. Semi-structured interviews with elders, chiefs, ritual specialists, and artisans,
5. Comparative historical analysis with neighboring cultural practices.

## **Literature and Research Materials**

1. Oral narratives and community memories,
2. Festival rituals and masquerade performances,
3. Material culture objects (*Odo* masks, *Uko* costumes).

## **Time and Work Plan**

**Year 1:** Literature review, archival research, refinement of research questions.

**Year 2:** Fieldwork and documentation of rituals, interviews, and performative practices.

**Year 3:** Data analysis, writing, revision, and submission.

## **References**

Osatohanmwon, A. R. (2024). *Understanding essentials of Igue festival of Benin people in promoting traditional peace*. *EBSU Journal of Social Sciences and Humanities*, 14(4). Retrieved from <https://ebsu-jssh.com/index.php/EBSUJSSH/article/view/187>

Osundiran, E. E., & Akinsola, I. (2025). *Cultural hybridity and marginality in selected contemporary Yoruba films*. *Journal of African History, Culture and Arts*. Retrieved from <https://journals.jozacpublishers.com/index.php/jahca/article/view/968>

Qani, M. I. (2025). *Ineffectiveness of alien terms interference in a culture of multilingual counties*. arXiv. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2501.18605>